institution that derives its authority from something other than the will of the people is anti-democratic. As the self-proclaimed representatives of the people, populists consequently seek to monopolise not just political authority but all types of authority and to take control of institutions such as media outlets, courts and universities. By taking the democratic principle of 'people's power' to its extreme, populists turn totalitarian.

In fact, while democracy means that authority *in the political sphere* comes from the people, it doesn't deny the validity of alternative sources of authority in other spheres. As discussed above, in a democracy independent media outlets, courts and universities are essential self-correcting mechanisms that protect the truth even from the will of the majority. Biology professors claim that humans evolved from apes because the evidence supports this, even if the majority wills it to be otherwise. Journalists can reveal that a popular politician took a bribe, and if compelling evidence is presented in court, a judge may send that politician to jail, even if most people don't want to believe these accusations.

Populists are suspicious of institutions that in the name of objective truths override the supposed will of the people. They tend to see this as a smoke screen for elites grabbing illegitimate power. This drives populists to be sceptical of the pursuit of truth, and to argue – as we saw in the prologue – that 'power is the only reality'. They thereby seek to undercut or appropriate the authority of any independent institutions that might oppose them. The result is a dark and cynical view of the world as a jungle and of human beings as creatures obsessed with power alone. All social interactions are seen as power struggles, and all institutions are depicted as cliques promoting the interests of their own members. In the populist imagination, courts don't really care about justice; they only protect the privileges of the judges. Yes, the judges talk a lot about justice, but this is a ploy to grab power for themselves. Newspapers don't care about facts; they spread fake news to mislead the people and benefit the journalists and the cabals that finance them. Even scientific institutions aren't committed to the truth. Biologists, climatologists, epidemiologists, economists, historians and mathematicians are just another interest group feathering its own nest – at the expense of the people.

In all, it's a rather sordid view of humanity, but two things nevertheless make it appealing to many. First, since it reduces all interactions to power struggles, it simplifies reality and makes events like wars, economic crises